Leadership Tool: 12 Question Guide to Identifying Outstanding Talent

Hiring the right candidate is a critical part of creating a great work culture. Utilizing behavior-based questions with a detailed rubric during the interview process is a strategy that can significantly enhance your chance of identifying the most suitable candidate for the team. This leadership tool will allow you to gain a deeper insight into a candidate's experiences, competencies, and potential fit within the company culture. This approach also promotes fairness and consistency, ensuring that all candidates are evaluated on the same criteria, thereby reducing bias and increasing the likelihood of making an informed, objective decision.

The following tool (and 12 questions) is one you can use to supplement your organization's interviewing guide or when you are short on time but still want to maximize the interview process. The rubric ensures that you are not only basing your decisions on a "gut feeling" but are backed by evidence and a thorough understanding of the candidate's capabilities. It will also help you to structure the dialogue, providing both a positive experience for you and the candidate. This sends a strong positive message about the organization's commitment (and your commitment as a leader) towards hiring and engagement, which in turn will attract individuals who value transparency and positive cultures.

Quick Note: *It is not important to ask all 12 questions (and there probably won't be time). Just select the questions that you believe will help you best determine which applicant would be best for the position and be sure to ask all applicants the same questions to ensure consistency in your evaluation.*

12 Question Guide to Identifying Outstanding Talent

Question 1: Can you describe a challenging situation at work and how you handled it?

Insight: This question will help you assess the candidate's problem-solving abilities, resilience, and the ability to work under different levels of pressure. It will also give you insight into the candidate's definition of "challenging."

- 4 Points (Excellent): Provided a specific, complex challenge, clearly describes a proactive and innovative approach, demonstrated critical thinking, and included positive outcomes with learnings.
- 3 points (Good): Describes a specific challenge, a thoughtful approach, includes positive outcomes, but the description of the process or learning may lack some depth.

- 2 points (Average): Mentions a challenge with a basic approach and/or outcome, also lacks detail or doesn't convey significant personal involvement or learning.
- 1 point (Poor): Vague about the challenge, the approach to address it was unclear or passive, and outcomes or learnings are minimal or negative.

Score: _____

Question 2: Can you give an example of a goal you set and how you achieved the goal?

Insight: This question evaluates a candidate's goal-setting skills and determination. It also provides insight into a candidate's approach to identifying goals and persistence.

- 4 Points (Excellent): Details a significant, challenging goal (for the level of work), describes a strategic and innovative approach to achieving the goal, includes obstacles overcome, and discusses significant results or learnings (listen to hear if the goal, when described by the candidate, is specific, measurable, attainable, realistic, time-bound).
- 3 points (Good): Describes a clear goal and approach with positive outcomes but may lack the depth of obstacles overcome or significant innovation in the approach.
- 2 points (Average): Mentions a goal with a straightforward approach and outcome, lacks details on the process or any specific challenges faced.
- 1 point (Poor): Provides a vague or irrelevant goal, with minimal or no explanation of the approach or outcomes.

Score: _____

Question 3: How do you prioritize your work when you have multiple deadlines to meet?

Insight: The question reveals the candidate's time management and organizational skills. It also provides depth into how they balance the quality of their work with deadlines.

- 4 Points (Excellent): The candidate describes a detailed and systematic approach for prioritizing task, including different tools or methods (like the Eisenhower Matrix or software tools). Additionally, the candidate demonstrates flexibility and includes examples of successfully meeting deadlines.
- 3 points (Good): Provides a clear method for prioritizing work with examples, but the approach may be more conventional without mentioning specific tools or methods.
- 2 points (Average): Describes basic prioritization (like first come, first served or deadline driven only), with limited or no examples.
- 1 point (Poor): Lacks a coherent strategy for prioritization, with no examples or poor outcomes.

Score: _____

Question 4: Tell me a time when you got critical or constructive feedback. How did you handle the feedback?

Insight: This question probes the candidate's ability to accept and constructively use feedback, which can indicate a potential for growth and receptiveness to learning. It also

provides some depth into how they like to receive feedback and if it matches your style of delivering feedback.

- 4 Points (Excellent): Describes a specific example and a positive, proactive response to critical feedback, including specific examples of seeking out feedback, reflecting on the feedback, and making concrete changes based on the feedback.
- 3 points (Good): Accepts and uses feedback to make changes, with examples, but may not demonstrate as proactive approach to seeking out feedback or reflecting in depth.
- 2 points (Average): Generally, accepts feedback but lacks specific examples or details on how it was used to make improvements. Very little reflection on the process.
- 1 point (Poor): Has no examples or is defensive and negative about receiving feedback.

Score: _____

Question 5: What do you think will be the biggest challenge in this job, and how would you address this issue?

Insight: The question assesses the candidate's understanding of the role, their analytical skills in anticipating challenges, and their proactive approach to problem solving. Additionally, it gives you a bit of insight into how much they investigated the job and the company prior to the interview.

- 4 Points (Excellent): Demonstrates a deep understanding of the role with a specific, relevant challenge identified, and offers a detailed, innovative solution strategy that aligns with the company values.
- 3 points (Good): Shows a solid understanding of the role, identifies an obvious but important challenge, and proposes a practical solution that generally aligns with the company values.
- 2 points (Average): Basic understanding of the role is evident; identifies a very generic challenge with a simplistic solution that lacks depth and understanding of the company.
- 1 point (Poor): Shows minimal (or no) understanding of the role, fails to identify a relevant challenge, and proposes a solution that is unrealistic or does not align with the company values.

Score: _____

Question 6: Describe a time when you disagreed with a decision at work. How did you handle it?

Insight: The question probes the candidate's conflict resolution skills, diplomacy, and the ability to navigate workplace politics constructively.

- 4 Points (Excellent): The candidate clearly articulates a significant disagreement with insightful reflection on the situation, demonstrates advanced conflict resolution skills, and communicates their stance in a highly constructive, professional manner that respects all parties involved.

- 3 points (Good): Describes a relevant disagreement and manages it with good communication skills. The candidate shows an understanding of conflict resolution principles, addressing the issue directly yet respectfully with a focus on finding a common ground or solution.
- 2 points (Average): Identifies a disagreement but handles it passively or with minimal direct communication. The candidate shows basic conflict resolution efforts with some attempt to maintain professionalism but lacks a clear strategy or effectiveness.
- 1 point (Poor): Offers a vague or inappropriate example of disagreement, with little to no constructive handling of the situation. The candidate demonstrates poor communication skills, a lack of professionalism, or an inability to effectively engage in conflict resolution.

Score: _____

Question 7: How do you stay updated with the latest trends in our industry?

Insight: The question assesses the candidate's commitment to continuous learning and whether they take initiative in personal development.

- 4 Points (Excellent): The candidate demonstrates a proactive and multifaceted approach to staying informed, including specific examples of engaging with advanced resources (like industry journals, conferences, online courses, professional networks) and clearly articulates how this knowledge is applied to their work.
- 3 points (Good): The candidate describes a solid, consistent approach to keeping up with trends through a variety of sources (industry publications or seminars) and provides examples of how this information has been useful in their professional development or work.
- 2 points (Average): Mentions some basic methods for staying informed, such as following popular industry blogs or social media, with limited or no examples of how this knowledge is applied in a professional context.
- 1 point (Poor): Provides vague or generic responses without specific sources or methods for staying updated or indicates minimal effort towards professional development and awareness of industry trends.

Score: _____

Question 8: Can you describe a project or idea (not necessarily your own) that was implemented primarily because of your efforts? Take me through the process of how it was implemented and how you contributed.

Insight: The question evaluates initiative, leadership potential, and the ability to influence or motivate others. Additionally, the question gives you some insight into how they work with others and the credit they are willing to give to others for project completion.

- 4 Points (Excellent): Provides a detailed description of a complex project or idea (that could be a valuable project or idea in this current role), highlighting significant personal initiative and leadership. Clearly articulates the process, including challenges faced and

how they were overcome, demonstrating exceptional problem-solving skills. Additionally, discusses the impact that others made in moving the project/idea along and gives proper credit to the team for successful completion of the project/idea.

- 3 points (Good): Describes involvement in a project or idea with clear personal contributions that show good problem-solving skills and collaboration. Outlines the process and personal role with examples of overcoming moderate challenges, leading to positive outcomes. Discusses the inclusion of others in helping to move the project/idea forward.
- 2 points (Average): Mentions participation in a project or idea with some contribution but details on the process and personal involvement are vague or show minimal challenge. Demonstrates basic problem-solving with limited impact. Spends very little time talking about the relationship or contribution of others to move the project forward.
- 1 point (Poor): Provides a vague or irrelevant example with little to no clear personal contribution or understanding of the project's implementation process. Lacks evidence of problem solving or impact. Did not discuss the contributions of others on project/idea success.

Score: _____

Question 9: How do you keep yourself organized and ensure you don't miss details in your work?

Insight: The question highlights the candidate's organizational skills, attention to detail, and how the candidate manages tasks and information.

- 4 Points (Excellent): The candidate describes a comprehensive systematic approach to organization and detail management, incorporating advanced tools and techniques (like project management tools and specific methodologies like time-blocking). Provides clear examples of how these strategies prevent oversight and improve efficiency in complex situations.
- 3 points (Good): Details a solid organizational strategy that includes the use of common tools (like calendars or to-do lists) and methods. Offers examples of how this approach helps in maintaining attention to detail and managing tasks effectively, though the examples may be less complex.
- 2 points (Average): Mentions very basic organizational habits (like keeping a list) without specific tools or methods. Provides general statements about their effectiveness with few to no concrete examples or outcomes.
- 1 point (Poor): The candidate provides vague or minimal information on how they stay organized with no mention of tools, strategies, or examples. Lacks clarity on how they ensure details are not missed, suggesting potential for oversight.

Score: _____

Question 10: Describe a time when you had to collaborate closely with a team to achieve a goal? What was your role? How did you contribute to the relationship formed on the team?

Insight: The question explores how the candidate works with others and builds positive relationships. Additionally, it assesses how the individual contributes to a team's success.

- 4 Points (Excellent): The candidate provides a detailed example of a collaborative effort highlighting a significant, challenging goal. They clearly define their role/contribution, demonstrating exceptional teamwork skills. They also discuss how their actions contributed to the positive culture of the group.
- 3 points (Good): The candidate describes a clear example of working within a team to meet a goal, specifying their role and contribution. They show good teamwork, and their response shows an understanding of team dynamics. They address the culture of the group but do not go into depth on how they created the culture.
- 2 points (Average): Provides a basic example of team collaboration with a general description of their role and contributions. It is clear though examples they did not play a significant role in achieving the team's goal and/or contributing to the culture of the team.
- 1 point (Poor): The candidate offers a vague or irrelevant example with minimal detail on their role or contributions to the team's efforts. Their response lacks insight into their understanding of team dynamics.

Score: _____

Question 11: Describe the best or most effective leader you have worked for in the past? What was it about this leader that made them effective?

Insight: The question provides depth into the type of leadership the candidate works best with and how they like to be managed. This insight can provide a deeper understanding of how this candidate will respond to your leadership style.

- 4 Points (Excellent): The candidate provides a detailed and specific example of an effective leader highlighting clear, distinct leadership qualities that contributed to their success. The candidate reflects on how these qualities impacted their own professional success and development.
- 3 points (Good): The candidate describes a leader and their effective qualities with good detail, focusing on commonly recognized leadership skills/abilities. The response includes examples of how these skills and abilities influenced them to complete their work.
- 2 points (Average): Mentions a leader and a few of their qualities but provides limited details or examples. Or they mention a leadership style that is very different than the one that will occur in this current position.
- 1 point (Poor): Provides a vague or generic description of a leader with no mention of specific qualities.

Score: _____

Question 12: Can you describe the work environment or culture in which you feel most productive and happy? What specific aspects of that environment make it ideal for you and how is an environment like that created?

Insight: The question provides depth into the type of culture a candidate works best in. This is an opportunity to assess whether the current work culture will work for the candidate. Additionally, the question assesses who the candidate believes is responsible for creating the culture.

- 4 Points (Excellent): The candidate provides a detailed and insightful description of their ideal work culture. They clearly articulate why these aspects are important to them and how they contributed to their productivity. The response also suggests that they believe that all members of the team are responsible for contributing to the work culture. Finally, the culture they described is similar to the current culture of the team/department/organization.
- 3 points (Good): The candidate describes a preferred work environment with several key characteristics identified. The candidate describes how these aspects contribute to their sense of productivity and well-being.
- 2 points (Average): Provides a very basic description of a preferred work culture with very few characteristics. The explanation of why this environment suits them is general or superficial. The candidate also places all the responsibility of the work culture on the organization or leader.
- 1 point (Poor): Offers a vague or generic response that lacks details or fails to identify specific aspects of work culture. There is little to no explanation of how this culture contributes to their success, suggesting a lack of self-awareness regarding an optimal work environment.

Score: _____

Total Score:

Add up the numbers for each question and divide by the number of questions asked for final score

Added Up Scores: _____

Number of Questions Asked: _____

Final Score: _____

Notes:

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